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CENTRE OF ATTENTION
Women stand in queue in Dharwad, Karnataka, in 2019, to cast their vote in the general election

assembly polls, too, in which the Congress wrested power from the BJP, the party made a similar pitch, promising Rs 1,500 a month to women.

The Congress is betting on the support of women voters in Karnataka now, mainly through grassroots action. Naa Nayaki conventions—the phrase means 'I am the leader', as spoken in a woman's voice—are being planned for every assembly constituency, says Karnataka Pradesh Mahila Congress chief Pushpa Amarnath. "Our Mahila Congress is working in wards, blocks and panchayats, going to each village." The outreach began with pilot programmes in Gadag and Ballari last year. The idea is to mobilise women working as farmers, street vendors or in other such small occupations, plus those who have contested local body polls. Their feedback is a key part—even the idea for the Gruha Lakshmi scheme came from listening to grievances about rising household expenditures, says Amarnath.

For the Congress, the Gruha Lakshmi scheme is its second poll offering against price rise after it made a similar promise recently, announcing 200 units of free electricity every month. Interestingly, these promises are being seen as a follow-through of the previous Congress regime's welfare initiatives, such as the free foodgrain distribution scheme 'Anna Bhagya'.

Meanwhile, the BJP, which held a two-day national executive meeting of its mahila morcha in Tumakuru on January 20, is planning its own outreach programme, with a women's convention slated for this month. As a counter to the Congress promise, the Grihini Shakti scheme aims to help women from Below Poverty Line families, CM Basavaraj Bommai said recently. In the previous budget, the Bommai government had earmarked Rs 43,188 crore for schemes related to women entrepreneurship and self-help groups, and the government is now heavily publicising these ahead of the polls. Earlier this month, while inaugurating irrigation works in the semi-arid districts of northeast Karnataka, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, too, dwelt on women's empowerment and spoke about the Jal Jeevan Mission, under which, he said, about 3.5 million households in the state have received piped water connection.

WITH THE KARNATAKA ASSEMBLY POLLS JUST A FEW MONTHS AWAY, BOTH CONGRESS AND THE BJP ARE VYING FOR WOMEN'S VOTES

Beyond this election-driven euphoria, however, Karnataka's women find themselves in the same boat as the rest of India's in terms of political representation. While the number of women contestants in assembly polls has risen over the years—in 2018, as many as 219 women contested the election as against 175 in 2013 and 107 in 2008—the state currently has only 10 elected women legislators, just 4 per cent of the 224-member House. Ironically, Karnataka had been a pioneer in introducing reservation for women in panchayats in the early 1980s. Now to see if this renewed focus on women voters in Karnataka translates into more representation in the state's politics? ■